the VHP's Matri Shakti and Durga Vahini, and the RSS-affiliated Rashtrasevika Samiti.[56] Women were 'active and prominent in the bloody riots that swept across India' in the wake of the movement in Ahmedabad, Bhagalpur and Mumbai. As Sarkar explained, the 'role of Rithambhara's audio-cassetted speech and Uma Bharati's propaganda tours in stoking ferocious anger and aggression against Muslims was memorable'.[57] After the Babri Masjid was demolished, Vijaya Raje Scindia reportedly said that she could now die in peace for she had seen her dream come true.[58]

Importantly, many of the women in the Ayodhya mobilisation, at various levels, were not simply mouthing or repeating narratives created by men. They had agency. Unlike 'most South Asian women, who achieve political prominence because of their relationships with influential men, women like Scindia, Rithambara and Uma Bharti were relatively independent of men in both their personal and political lives', the political scientist Amrita Basu noted. In fact, she went so far as to argue that they had found 'within Hindu nationalism a vehicle for redressing their experiences of gender inequality and for transgressing sex-typed roles'.[59] Tanika Sarkar, who wrote a series of papers and a fine book on Hindu nationalism and women in the 1990s, described her fieldwork with the RSS's women's wing workers as profoundly 'confounding and disconcerting'. This, she explained, was because Leftist feminist thinkers had 'always celebrated the release of women from pure domesticity' and their politicisation 'had always been assumed to be an emancipatory possibility'. In other words, feminist movement leaders had always thought of the 'relationship between communal violence and women' as one of 'male-inflicted violence and female victimhood'. But the reality 'confounded certainties and forced new trajectories'.[60]

The Hindu nationalist women challenged the certitudes and ideas of the Left-led feminist movement. An earlier generation of RSS leaders had extolled traditional roles for women. Yet, Sarkar's study found that the women she dealt with were independent-minded and aware of their rights. Importantly, they were 'little concerned about westernised modernity'. 'In fact, the new Hindu woman citizen,' she wrote, 'is cast in a mould which is very close to that of